

Sentinels of the Dawn

Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration
Monastere Notre Dame des Anges
Troyes, France

Easter 2011 Issue 10

Behind the Scenes



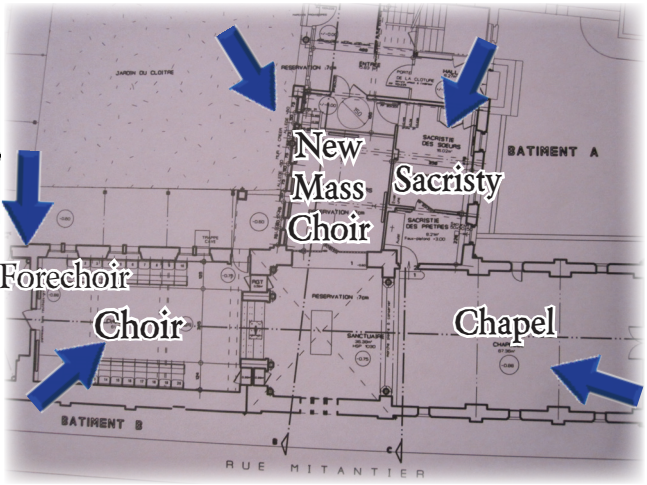
We brought in the New Year by clearing out the main chapel and settling into our temporary chapel.



Behind the fence, Ma Belle, our guard dog, surveys the workers. These past few months she has been working overtime. Her daily routine is announcing their times of arrival and departure.











The silence and solitude of a monastery. The noise and dust of a construction site. Since the beginning of January when the renovation work began on our Chapel, we have been living between these two worlds Somehow, we have managed to continue our daily rythmn of work and prayer without interruption!

From the time of our arrival in 2007, we have hoped to repaint and restore our Chapel, Choir and Forechoir. For three years we prayed; for three years we waited; for three years our desire to begin the renovation of our Chapel grew and grew. What's more, the Lord gave us a dream: to create a Chapel to the side of the Sanctuary where the Sisters would participate in the Mass without having to leave the Enclosure. The dream was almost scrapped, however, because of what seemed like structural impediments. Then, the Lord inspired our architect, Monsieur Jacques Téqui. Thanks to his expertise and creativity, the side wall of the Sanctuary now opens into what will be the Sisters' Mass Chapel. The Sacristy area has been renovated and the area near our new Enclosure Door will be given its proper importance. Mr. Téqui's great respect for our contemplative, cloistered life and his faith in the Eucharistic Mystery are manifested in the beautiful plans that he designed for these sacred spaces. May their simplicity and beauty evangelize, energize, and inspire all who enter.

Day by day, step by step, the stone masons, the carpenters, the electricians, and the heating crews have been hard at work. Despite the dust and noise, we see a beautiful transformation taking place, a transformation in which many of you have participated. Without the generosity of our benefactors, and the help of the Fondation des Monastères in Paris, we could never have begun this project. We pray that God may reward all those who have consecrated their time, talents and generosity to renew our little Chapel where people have come for generations to participate in Mass or the Divine Office and to pray in silent adoration before the Most Blessed Sacrament.

With most of the structural work behind us, phase one comes to an end. As work continues to progress, we look forward to sharing more updates with you. Please join us in giving thanks to God for His goodness in allowing us to start this project, which we hope to see completed in June. May it give Him glory and honor.



Every community therefore has the duty to take special care of its own sacred buildings, which are a precious religious and historical patrimony. For this we call upon the intercession of Mary Most Holy, that she help us to become, like her, the 'house of God,' living temples of his love.

- Pope Benedict XVI, Feast of the Dedication of the Lateran Basilica, November 9, 2008

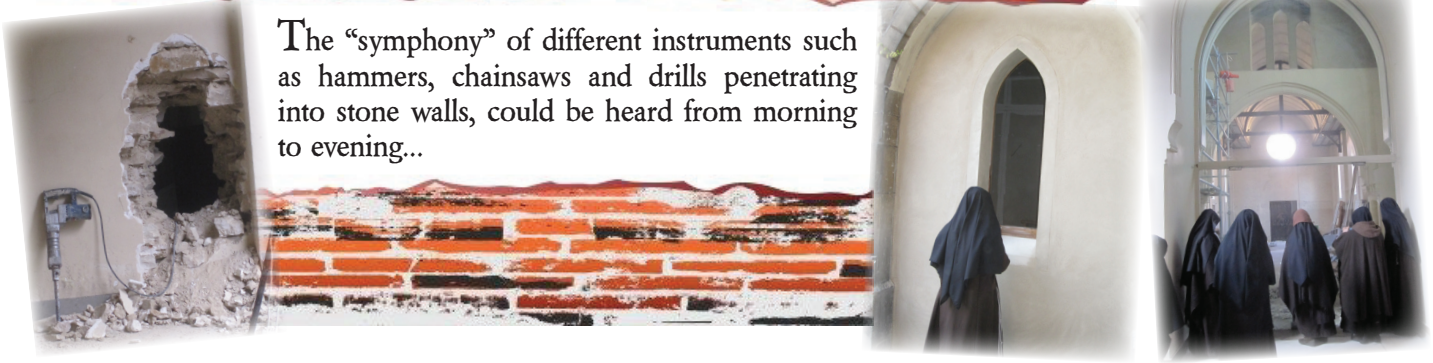




The Sisters new Mass Choir and the sacristy begin to take shape...



The "symphony" of different instruments such as hammers, chainsaws and drills penetrating into stone walls, could be heard from morning to evening...



GO TO THE SOURCE !

For the 12th consecutive year, the Pascal March took place in our diocese. Several hundred youth, accompanied by our bishop, priests, religious and other adults, gathered together on the evening of Easter Sunday to celebrate the Ressurection of Christ. The march provided an opportunity for times of reflection and prayer, as well as giving the participants a sense of being one body in Christ. Beginning at 8:15 pm., the group made their way along the open country roads, pasing from village to village until they reached their final destination at the break of dawn the following morning. The march closed with the Holy Mass, celebrated by Bishop Marc Stenger.

Throughout the course of the night, walking (17K) was intermingled with periods of rest. These pauses offered times of prayer, listening to differents Bible passages, and witnesses from a variety of people. They also allowed for activities such as short dramas, adoration, veneration of the cross, and carrying it from village to village. The sacrament of reconciliation was also made available.

We give thanks to God for all the graces that these "pilgrims" received in seeking to be refreshed by the true "source" of life, Jesus Christ. May this gathering strenghten their faith and their relation with Him, who is the Way, the Truth and the Life. As cloistered religious, our way of participating in the march was through prayer. We were happy to receive a copy of the booklet from this event. In it we discovered a beautiful reflection from our Bishop which we would like to share with you :

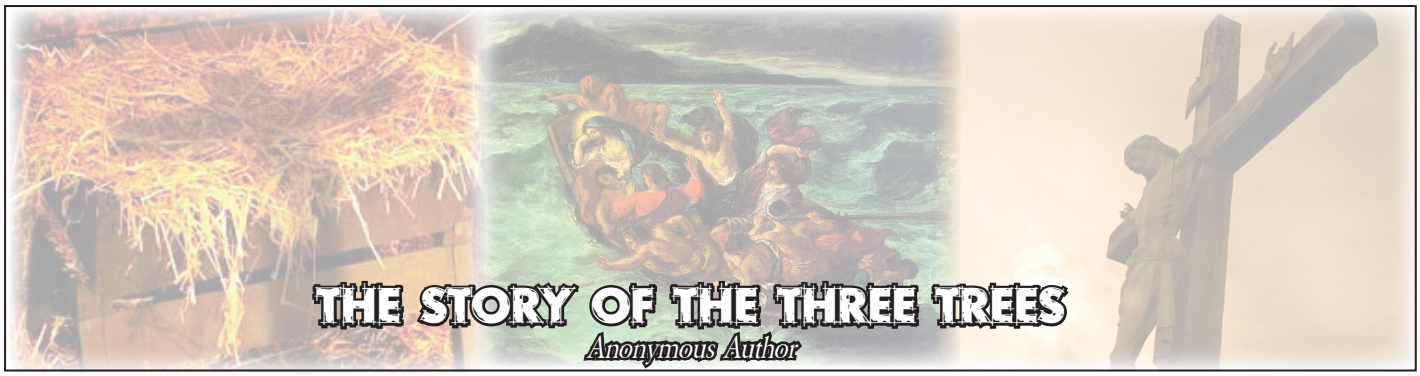
When we are thirsty, fresh water tastes good. We do not need to add all sorts of chemical additives to sweeten or flavor it.

It's the same thing with Jesus. If we are thirsty for happiness, peace, light, a purpose in life, we cannot help but be drawn to and filled by the freshness of His Word of life, as were so many men and women whose path He crossed on the roads of Palestine. Nourished and quenched by this Word, we will no longer be laden down by all sorts of strange theories to explain with our reason the inexplicable of love.

On this night of the "Pascal March", we are also on the road. We will meet Christ, we will listen to Him, as did the disciples on the road to Emmaus. For them, it was a stranger who opened their hearts. As for us, may it be with those whom we are sharing His Word on the way and with whom we want to "go to the source". And may nothing of this treasure be lost, no more than we would want to lose the cup with which we will draw water to quench the body's thirst.

Bishop Marc Stenger
Diocese of Troyes





THE STORY OF THE THREE TREES

Anonymous Author

Once upon a mountain top, three little trees stood and dreamed of what they wanted to become when they grew up. The first little tree looked up at the stars and said: "I want to hold treasure. I want to be covered with gold and filled with precious stones. I'll be the most beautiful treasure chest in the world!" The second little tree looked out at the small stream trickling by on its way to the ocean. "I want to be traveling mighty waters and carrying powerful kings. I'll be the strongest ship in the world!" The third little tree looked down into the valley below where busy men and women worked in a busy town. "I don't want to leave the mountain top at all. I want to grow so tall that when people stop to look at me, they'll raise their eyes to heaven and think of God. I will be the tallest tree in the world."

Years passed and the little trees grew tall. One day three woodcutters climbed the mountain. The first woodcutter looked at the first tree and said, "This tree is beautiful. It is perfect for me." With a swoop of his shining ax, the first tree fell. "Now I shall be made into a beautiful chest, I shall hold wonderful treasure!" the first tree said. The second woodcutter looked at the second tree and said, "This tree is strong. It is perfect for me." With a swoop of his shining ax, the second tree fell. "Now I shall sail mighty waters!" thought the second tree. "I shall be a strong ship for mighty kings!" The third tree felt her heart sink when the last woodcutter looked her way. She stood straight and tall and pointed bravely to heaven. But the woodcutter never even looked up. "Any kind of tree will do for me." He muttered. With a swoop of his shining ax the third tree fell.

The first tree rejoiced when the woodcutter brought her to a carpenter's shop. But the carpenter fashioned the tree into a feed box for animals. The once beautiful tree was not covered with gold, nor with treasure. She was coated with sawdust and filled with hay for hungry farm animals. The second tree smiled when the woodcutter took her to a shipyard, but no mighty ship was made that day. Instead, the once strong tree was hammered and sawed into a simple fishing boat. She was too small and too weak to sail to an ocean, or even a river. Instead she was taken to a little lake. The third tree was confused when the woodcutter cut her into strong beams and left her in a lumberyard. "What happened?" The once tall tree wondered. "All I ever wanted was to stay on the mountain top and point to God..."

Many, many days and nights passed. The three trees nearly forgot their dreams. But one night, golden starlight poured over the first tree as a young woman placed her newborn baby in the feed box. "I wish I could make a cradle for him," her husband whispered. "This manger is beautiful," she said. And suddenly the first tree knew he was holding the greatest treasure in the world.

One evening a tired traveler and his friends crowded into the old fishing boat. The traveler fell asleep as the second tree quietly sailed out into the lake. Soon a thundering and thrashing storm arose. The little tree shuddered. She knew she did not have the strength to carry so many passengers safely through the wind and the rain. The tired man awakened. He stood up, stretched out his hand and said, "Peace." The storm stopped as quickly as it had begun. And suddenly the second tree knew he was carrying the King of heaven and earth.

One Friday morning, the third tree was startled when her beams were yanked from the forgotten woodpile. She flinched as she was carried through an angry jeering crowd. She shuddered when soldiers nailed a man's hands to her. She felt ugly and harsh and cruel. But on Sunday morning, when the sun rose and the earth trembled with joy beneath her, the third tree knew that God's love had changed everything. It had made the third tree strong. And every time people thought of the third tree, they would think of God.

(The next time you are disappointed because you didn't get what you want, know that God is thinking of something better to give you!)



Our chapel is not the only site in the midst of construction. Our website is also "under construction", as we are currently in the process of updating the pages. We are looking forward in the next few months to be able to supply our "viewers" with an entirely new layout, different text and photos. By means of this wonderful tool of technology, it is our hope that you will find a source of inspiration, as you discover the beauty of our "hidden life in Christ". We will keep you posted on further updates in the near future. Your prayers are appreciated for the completion of this project, that it may give glory to God.



A Light throughout the Centuries: Saint Clare of Assisi



Palm Sunday evening, 1211. Claire, a young noble woman of Assisi flees from her home, and ventures to the little Church of the Portiuncula. It is here that she is received by Francis and his companions. Inspired to embrace the radical evangelical ideal of Francis, Clare embarks on a life of penance and consecration. A new order is born.

Palm Sunday 2011 marks the opening of the 8th centenary of the foundation of the Order of the Poor Sisters of Saint Clare. The year will close on August 11th, 2012. "The anniversary is not a commemoration of a glorious past", but an event that we remember in order to "to take from its history a further impetus to renew the will to serve the Church." (Benedict XVI) In praise and thanksgiving to God, the daughters of Saint Clare celebrate this year the birth of a gospel adventure that continues to give life to the Church today.

On that particular evening, Clare's flame of love was enkindled and began to shine, clear, as her name. Eight centuries later, this same light continues to burn in the hearts of her daughters. This vocation radiates in the life of each sister who takes in her hands the living and burning torch of Clare's charism. Thank you, Holy Mother Clare, for the total gift of yourself to Christ, the gift of being a poor and simple sister, of being a flame of hidden and silent prayer.

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Easter is filled with images of new life: a beautiful sunrise; flowers in bloom; the Paschal candle just beginning to burn; newly blessed water and the newly baptized. Christ has conquered sin and overcome death in the new life of Resurrection. Through the sacrament of baptism we embrace this new life in Christ.



Let us rejoice and be glad on this glorious day of Easter… The Lord is risen! He reigns in the glory of heaven at the right hand of the Father. By the power of the Holy Spirit this same Risen Jesus lives in the Church for we are the living body of Christ in the world. This same Risen Lord dwells in our hearts. This is the day that the Lord has made! We embrace a new beginning in the Lord, all of us who believe and are baptized. Our Easter song is: ALLELUIA!

May the blessings of our Risen Lord fill you with His peace, joy and love. We remember you in our prayers before His loving presence in the Most Blessed Sacrament.

Your Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration in Troyes, France